

Reading into Writing – Social Media

Last year, 3.96 billion people used social media, which is more than half the world's population. Is this cause for concern?

Extract One:

Adapted from: Kross, E., Verduyn, P., Sheppes, G., Costello, C. K., Jonides, J., & Ybarra, O. (2021). Social media and well-being: Pitfalls, progress, and next steps. *Trends in cognitive sciences*, 25(1), 55-66.

In 1956, Erving Goffman published a landmark book titled *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*. It argued that life is like a dramatic performance. According to Goffman, we are acting all the time. A great deal of research and theory supports Goffman's thesis: we spend much of our time trying to manage what others think of us.

There are, however, limits to the degree that we can engage in this process offline. Countless unpredictable obstacles can get in the way of presenting our best selves. Social media, by contrast, provide us with new opportunities to curate the way we present ourselves. We can post our most glamorous photographs and upload our wittiest posts. Managing how we present ourselves in this way can have positive consequences. But curating the way we present ourselves on social media can also have unintended negative consequences: it can lead us to feel worse when we compare our own lives against those we see depicted on social media.

Social comparisons are a cross-cultural phenomenon that emerge in early childhood and have deep evolutionary roots. We engage in them because they provide us with often useful information regarding how we stack up against our peers. However, when we compare ourselves to people on social media who are outperforming us, we end up feeling envy and distress. To put the magnitude of this issue in perspective, consider one study that asked 37,729 participants from 18 different countries to indicate whether they had compared themselves with

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others on Facebook over the past 2 weeks in a way that made them feel badly. Approximately 8500 participants – 22.5% of the sample – answered affirmatively. If you think about these results in terms of the close to 3 billion people who use Facebook, they raise the possibility that a substantial portion of people may be negatively impacted by engaging in social comparisons.

Decades of research indicate that when we experience strong positive and negative emotions, we are intensely motivated to share them. Social media provide people with unprecedented opportunities to pursue these goals by allowing us to instantly connect with people we are close to. Indeed, a wide range of studies indicate that social media provide feedback that satisfies people's socio-emotional and cognitive needs. In some cases, the support benefits that people derive from social media outweigh those they obtain in the offline world.

But just as social media provide us with new opportunities to seek and provide support, they also allow us to share our feelings in ways that hurt others. In this vein, a large literature shows that social media provide people with platforms for cyberbullying and trolling. Although individual differences play a role in determining who engages in these acts, certain features of social media promote them. For example, social media strip away cues that activate empathic responses during face-to-face interactions, which constrain aggressive behaviour. They also make it easier for people to share their emotions when they peak and are most motivated to do so. Social media also plays a role in spreading moral outrage, which contributes to the dehumanization of others and may reduce collective action and deepen social divides.

In conclusion, social media, like the printing press, represent a kind of disruptive technology that appears once in a generation. Over the past 15 years science has done an admirable job advancing our understanding of the impact these media have on our well-being, but the work is by no means complete. Numerous questions remain. And, we suspect the next 15 years will be ripe with discoveries that advance our understanding of how this ubiquitous technology influences our emotional lives.

Extract Two:

Adapted from: Esteban Ortiz-Ospina (2019) - "Are Facebook and other social media platforms bad for our well-being?" Published online at OurWorldInData.org. Retrieved from: '<https://ourworldindata.org/social-media-wellbeing>' [Online Resource]

Facebook, Youtube, Whatsapp, WeChat, and Instagram are the top five social media platforms globally, with over one billion active users each. In most rich countries the proportion of young people using online social networks exceeds 90% and teens spend on average more than 4 hours online every day.

We're repeatedly told in the news that social media is bad for us. The stories are often alarming, suggesting social media and smartphones are responsible for sweeping negative trends, from rising suicide rates in the US, to widespread loss in memory, and reduced sleep and attention spans.

These worrying headlines often go together with implicit or explicit recommendations to limit the amount of time we spend on social media. Indeed, smartphones today come with built-in "screen time" apps that let us track and limit how much time we spend online.

At the same time, most of us would agree that digital social media platforms can make our lives easier in many ways – opening doors to new information, connecting us with people who are far away, and helping us to be more flexible with work.

What does the research tell us about the causal impact of social media use on our well-being? In a nutshell: From my reading of the scientific literature, I do not believe that the available evidence today supports the sweeping newspaper headlines. Yes, there is evidence suggesting a causal negative effect, but the size of these causal effects is heterogeneous and much, much smaller than the news headlines suggest.

So, what are the key takeaways from the research?

The first takeaway is that the association between social media and well-being is complex and reciprocal, which means that simple correlations can be misleading. A careful analysis of survey data reveals that, yes, there is a correlation between social media and well-being; but the relationship works both ways.

This becomes clear from the longitudinal studies: Higher use of social media predicts decreases in life satisfaction; and decreasing life satisfaction also predicts subsequent increases in social media use.

The second takeaway is that the causal effect of social media on well-being is likely small for the average person. The best empirical evidence suggests the impact is much smaller than many news stories suggest and most people believe.

There is much to be learned about how to make better use of these digital platforms, and there is an important discussion to be had about the opportunity costs of spending a large fraction of our time online. But for this we need to look beyond the sweeping newspaper headlines.

We need research with more granular data to unpack diverse use patterns, to understand the different effects that certain types of content have on specific population groups. Time alone is a poor metric to gauge effects. As Andrew Przybylski put it: nobody would argue we should study the causes of obesity by investigating 'food time'.

Going forward, the conversation in policy and the news should be much more about strategies to promote positive content and interactions, than about one-size-fits-all restrictions on social media 'screen time'.

Extract Three:

Adapted from: Lee, A. Y., & Hancock, J. T. (2024). Social media mindsets: A new approach to understanding social media use and psychological well-being. *Journal of Computer-Mediated Communication*, 29(1)

Since social media has become a mainstay of modern communication, people have struggled to understand what to make of its role in their lives. While some believe social media can be leveraged as a tool to improve connection at scale, others fear that our recurrent use has become a dependency that undermines our autonomy. Indeed, one of the most dominant concerns about technology revolves around how social media affects psychological well-being.

Scholars, technologists, and policymakers alike have raised concerns about the potential for social media to exacerbate depression (Twenge et al., 2018), increase anxiety (Wells et al., 2021), and cause addiction to devices (Brailovskaia et al., 2021; Klobuchar & Lumming, 2022). For example, teen depression and suicidality track with increases in social media use, suggesting that social media may be harming young people on a massive scale (Haidt, 2022). In the policy sphere, congressional hearings have been convened to investigate the effects of social media on mental health (Kang, 2021). And the majority of American parents today feel worried about the psychological consequences of their children spending too much time on their devices (Auxier & Anderson, 2021; Woolford et al., 2023).

Findings from the academic literature on the effects of social media on psychological well-being, however, are decidedly more mixed. Some studies appear to corroborate the fears people have, finding that individuals who use social media tend to feel more depressed and psychologically distressed. These negative experiences appear to be particularly pronounced among people who feel their use is out of their control.

However, recent examinations of large, nationally representative datasets have challenged the notion that social media is as harmful as often feared (Orben &

Przybylski, 2019; Vuorre et al., 2021). Instead, they found that digital technology use explained minimal variation in well-being – less than the influence of other important factors such as sleep, diet, and exercise (Orben & Przybylski, 2019).

Similarly, recent meta-analyses (Hancock et al., 2022; Odgers & Jensen, 2020; Meier & Reinecke, 2021) have found small, mixed effects of social media use on well-being. In fact, these meta-analyses highlight that social media use can also enhance well-being by strengthening relationships and connecting individuals to communities of people like them (Minihan et al., 2023).

In addition, growing research demonstrates that effects vary substantially from person to person. When considering the influence of social media use on affective well-being, for example, Beyens et al. (2021) found that engaging with social media improved well-being for 26% of adolescents, harmed well-being in another 28%, and did not influence the well-being of 45%.

Recent research reflects these patterns, finding that people's orientations toward social media are driven by core beliefs about the amount of agency they feel they have over their use of social media ("Is social media something that I can control, or something that controls me?"), and the perceived valence of social media's effect on their lives ("Are the effects of using social media enhancing or harmful for me?") (Lee et al., 2021). The core beliefs held by individuals orient their expectations, behaviours, attributions, and goals regarding the role of social media in their lives.